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some spp). The apparent aerial erect, unbranched tall pseudostem is formed by the long stiff and sheathy leaf bases which are rolled around one another to form an aerial pseudostem. The central axis that is concealed at the bottom of the pseudostem in called shaft, which elongates and pierces through the pseudostem at the time of flowering and produces inflorescence terminally. **monocorpic** in *Musa*. (produces flowers and fruits once during its life time). Stem is aerial and woody in *Ravenala madagascariensis.*

Leaf: Simple with long and strong petiole the leaf blade is large and broad with sheathy leaf base. The leaf is exstipulate. Oval, obtuse or oblong with a stout midrib, entire, numerous parallel veins extending up to the margin, rolled in bud . Phyllotaxy is spiral in *Musa* and distichous i.e. leaves are arranged alternately in two opposite vertical rows in *Ravenala*.

Inflorescence: Terminal or axillary thyrse of one to many monochasial branched spadix in *Musa*, Usually the flowers are protected by large brightly coloured, spirally arranged, boat shaped bract called spathe. Compound cyme in *Ravenala.*

Flowers: Bracteate, ebracteolate, sessile, trimerours, unisexual, or bisexual or polygamous, when unisexual the flowers are monoecious. Flowers are zygyomorphic and epigynous. (In *Musa* flowers are polygamous i.e. staminate flowers, pistilate flowers and bisexual flowers are present in the same plant).

Perianth: Tepals 6, biseriate, arranged in two whorls of 3 each and homochlamydeous, 3 +3 syntepalous. In most of the species of *Musa,* the three outer tepals and two lateral tepals of the inner whorl are fused to form 5 toothed tube like structure called **abaxial lip**. The posterior inner median tepal alone is free, which is distinctly broad and membranous called **labellum**.

Androecium: Stamens 5 or 6, arranged in two whorls of 3 each opposite and adnate to the tepals. In *Musa* only 5 stamens are fertile and the inner posterior stamen is either absent or represented by a staminode. In *Ravenala* all the six stamens are fertile. Filaments free, anthers linear, dithecous dehisce by longitudinal slits, and with sticky pollen.

Gynoecium: Tricarpallary, syncarpous, the median carpel is anterior in position, trilocular ovary inferior, ovules many, placentation axile, style filiform, stigma three lobed septal nectaries are present.

Fruit: Elongated berry containing numerous seeds, fruits forming compact bunches, seeds with copious and small embryo in *Musa*. Capsule in *Ravenala.*

Seed: Starch rich endosperm and starchless perisperm. Species of *Ensete* are distinguished from those of *Musa* by their larger seeds.

Botanical Description of *Musa paradisiaca.*

Habit: Monocarpic gigantic herb.

Root: Fibrous adventitious root system.

Stem: The real stem is underground called rhizomatous. The apparent, aerial erect unbranched pseudo stem is formed by the long, stiff and sheathy leaf bases which are rolled around one another to form an aerial pseudostem. The central